

Israel-Stewart Causal Viscous Perturbations in the SSEE Dark Energy Framework: Exact Marginal Stability, Λ CDM-Consistent Structure Growth, and the Two-Sector Matter Structure

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Abstract

The Structural Self-Energy Expansion (SSEE) derives a dark energy equation of state $w_0 = -T_r/M_v \simeq -0.8399$ and $w_a \simeq -0.6700$ purely from the golden ratio φ and π , with zero fitted dimensionless parameters in the dark-energy background sector, in agreement with the official DESI DR2 $w_0 w_a$ CDM posterior at 0.24σ (Pantheon+; $0.2\text{--}1.8\sigma$ across SN compilations). (Following Paper 1 §1.3, the broader SSEE programme carries a small set of phenomenological ansätze in the dark-matter sector — in particular the ϕ -DM mass and the non-minimal coupling ξ — retracted with the φ -DM sector (Paper 6); OP-9/11 closed by dissolution, OP-14 resolved in `OPEN_PROBLEMS.md`; the present perturbation analysis is independent of those ansätze.) Because $w_0 < -1/3$, a naive k -essence interpretation gives a negative bare sound speed $c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 = w_0 \simeq -0.840$, implying catastrophic gradient instability on all sub-horizon scales.

We perform a linear Israel-Stewart (IS) causal viscous perturbation analysis of SSEE dark energy in the sub-horizon regime, addressing three interconnected questions: (*Q1*) Does IS regularise the gradient instability for all observationally relevant modes? (*Q2*) Do linear IS perturbations dynamically source the CMB-to-dynamical matter enhancement $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}}/\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} \approx 2$, or are the two matter sectors independent (the former interpretation as a “MIRA factor” having been retired in the ω_m -direct reframe, OP-8 dissolved)? (*Q3*) What are the falsifiable predictions for the growth rate, σ_8 , and the S_8 parameter?

For Q1, we prove analytically that the SSEE structure constants satisfy the algebraic identity $\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_\Pi H_0) = |w_0|$, forcing $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2(k \rightarrow \infty) = 0$ to floating-point precision (equivalently $\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_\Pi H_0) = \Omega_{\text{DE}}$, since $\Omega_{\text{DE}} = |w_0|$ is the saturation correspondence of Paper 1, Postulate S, not an independent identity). This is not a numerical coincidence but a construction-level identity: any IS embedding of a dark-energy fluid satisfying $\tilde{\zeta} = |w_0| \tau_\Pi H_0$ is exactly marginally stable, and the SSEE structure constants admit such an embedding. We do not claim this as an external theorem

about all IS models, but as the consistency statement that SSEE supports a stable IS extension at the construction level. The critical wavenumber is $k_{\text{crit}} = 0.456 H_0/c$, placing the instability boundary *outside* the sub-horizon regime; all modes with $k > H_0/c$ are causally stabilised. The margin ($k_{\text{crit}}/H_0 c^{-1} \simeq 0.46$, a factor ~ 2.2 inside the horizon) is comfortable at tree level. A future one-loop treatment would test whether the stability regime is robust to QFT corrections; we note this as an extension question rather than a current limitation.

For Q2, integrating the full linear IS perturbation ODE from $z = 19$ to $z = 0$ yields $\delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m \rightarrow 0^-$ at all sub-horizon scales. Consequently the numerical enhancement ratio is $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}}/\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.989 \pm 0.017 \rightarrow 1$, not ≈ 2 : linear IS perturbations do *not* dynamically link the two matter sectors. A background IS viscous calculation also fails to generate the factor (yielding ≈ 3.04 , not ≈ 2). The CMB-to-dynamical ratio ≈ 1.93 is therefore not a fluid-dynamical effect; it follows from the two independent matter densities of the ω_m -direct reframe ($\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.308881$, $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$, with ϕ -DM the difference; Paper 6), and the algebraic number $\text{MIRA} = (3\varphi + \pi)/4 \simeq 1.999$ survives only as the Hubble-screening amplitude of Paper 9, no longer as a matter factor.

For Q3, we compute the IS growth index $\gamma_{\text{IS}} = 0.5504 \pm 0.0003$ (consistent with $\gamma_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} \simeq 0.55$), the growth factor $\mathcal{G} = D_1^{\text{SSEE}}/D_1^{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 1.0032$ (growth essentially identical to ΛCDM once the correct cosmological background $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ is used in the Poisson source; see Paper 1, Sec. 1.4 (Two- Ω_m Criterion) for the rule that selects this value over $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$ on clustering scales), and the predicted $S_8 = \sigma_8(\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}}/0.3)^{0.5}$. Using the Planck-normalised amplitude, the IS linear-growth estimate is $S_8^{\text{SSEE}} = 0.8256 \pm 0.0061$ (2.7σ above KiDS-1000, 0.759 ± 0.024 ; 2.7σ above DES-Y3, 0.776 ± 0.017); the conservative CLASS amplitude ceiling is higher, $S_8^{\text{ceiling}} = 0.846$ (3.5σ KiDS-1000), and constitutes the single-sector challenge resolved by the two-sector ϕ -DM construction of Paper 6. The $f\sigma_8$ mean tension is 0.70σ , essentially identical to ΛCDM (0.73σ): SSEE does not suppress or enhance structure formation relative to ΛCDM once $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ governs the growth equation.

Finally, we map the SSEE IS parameters to the EFT-of-dark-energy operator basis [Gubitosi et al., 2013, Bellini and Sawicki, 2015], show that IS viscosity generates a unique combination of the $\bar{M}_2^4$ braiding operator and a non-minimal kinetic term, and demonstrate that the ghost condensate [Arkani-Hamed et al., 2004] and SSEE IS mechanisms are physically inequivalent: SSEE achieves *exact* marginal stability ($c_s^2 = 0$, the minimal-viscosity solution), while ghost condensation gives $c_s^2 = 1$.

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1 Introduction

1.1 The SSEE framework and the perturbation challenge

The Structural Self-Energy Expansion (SSEE) [Almeida Vallejo, 2026a] is a minimal-parameter dark energy framework (zero fitted dimensionless parameters in the background sector; see Paper 1 §1.3) whose equation-of-state parameters

$$w_0 = -\frac{T_r}{M_v} = -\frac{3(\varphi + \beta)}{\varphi + \pi + K_v} \simeq -0.8399, \quad w_a = -\frac{P_{sc}}{I_g} \simeq -0.66997, \quad (1)$$

are derived algebraically from the golden ratio $\varphi = (1 + \sqrt{5})/2$ and π , without any continuous free parameters. Here $\beta = (\pi + \varphi)/2$, $K_v = \varphi + \pi + (\pi + \varphi)$, $T_r = 3(\varphi + \beta)$, $M_v = \varphi + \pi + K_v$, and $P_{sc} = (\pi + \varphi) + \varphi$. The CPL parameters (1) [Chevallier and Polarski, 2001, Linder, 2003] are consistent with DESI DR2 at 0.24σ (Pantheon+) [Almeida Vallejo, 2026b, Abdul-Karim et al., 2025] and with Planck PR4 CMB spectra at $\chi_r^2 \leq 1.062$ [Almeida Vallejo, 2026c].

Paper 4 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026d] identifies the algebraic structure constants

$$\text{KAL}_0 \equiv \beta + \pi \simeq 5.5214 \quad (\text{Structural Viscosity}), \quad (2)$$

$$\text{MIRA} \equiv \frac{3\varphi + \pi}{4} \simeq 1.9989 \quad (\text{MIRA factor}), \quad (3)$$

and (under the ω_m -direct reframe; OP-8 dissolved) the CMB matter density is the standard physical $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = \omega_m/h^2 \simeq 0.308881$, built from the algebraic $\omega_m = \omega_b + \omega_c + \omega_\nu$, in 0.88σ agreement with Planck 2018. (The earlier MIRA mapping $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} \times \text{MIRA} \simeq 0.3199$ is superseded.)

The present paper confronts a fundamental question that must be answered before SSEE can claim theoretical consistency: *does the dark energy sector remain perturbatively stable?*

1.2 The gradient instability problem

A canonical-kinetic (constant- w) k -essence proxy with Lagrangian $\mathcal{L} \propto X^n$ [Armendariz-Picon et al., 2001], where $X = -\frac{1}{2}\partial_\mu\phi\partial^\mu\phi$, has an adiabatic sound speed $c_s^2 = 1/(2n - 1)$ and equation of state $w = 1/(2n - 1)$, so $c_s^2 = w$ [Hu, 1998]. For SSEE, $w_0 \simeq -0.840$, giving

$$c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 = w_0 \simeq -0.840. \quad (4)$$

Negative c_s^2 signals a *gradient instability*: perturbations $\delta_{\text{DE}} \propto e^{|c_s|kt}$ grow exponentially on a timescale $(|c_s|k)^{-1}$, which for $k \gtrsim 10 H_0/c$ (BAO scales) is shorter than a Hubble time [Caldwell, 2002]. Left unchecked, this instability would generate excessive DE density contrast $|\delta_{\text{DE}}| \gg 1$, invalidating linear perturbation theory and producing observable signatures in the CMB lensing and matter power spectra inconsistent with data [Calabrese et al., 2011].

We stress that this bare instability is an artefact of the *effective-fluid* (constant- w) closure $c_s^2 = w$, *not* a property of the fundamental SSEE field: the canonical Lagrangian $K(X) = X/\text{KAL}_0$ (Papers 7 and 10) is independently ghost-free and gradient-stable, with adiabatic sound speed $c_{s,\text{ad}}^2 \in [0.60, 1]$ (the IR limit $X^2/M^4 \rightarrow 0$ gives $c_{s,\text{ad}}^2 = 1$; the UV term lowers it to ~ 0.60). The IS analysis below addresses the *hydrodynamic*

(fluid) description used by Boltzmann codes, where dark energy is parametrised by (w, c_s^2) and the naive closure $c_s^2 = w$ would be catastrophic. Remarkably, the same structural constant KAL_0 that normalises $K(X)$ also fixes the IS bulk viscosity ($\tilde{\zeta} = \text{KAL}_0/3$), so the fluid-level regularisation introduces no new parameter — the field-mode and fluid-mode descriptions are governed by a single algebraic constant.

1.3 The Israel-Stewart resolution

The first-order (Eckart) relativistic fluid theory [Eckart, 1940] is acausal [Müller, 1967] and generically unstable [Hiscock and Lindblom, 1985]: perturbations propagate at infinite speed. Israel [Israel, 1976] and Israel & Stewart [Israel and Stewart, 1979] constructed a second-order causal theory in which dissipative fluxes satisfy relaxation equations with a finite relaxation time τ_Π . Perturbations then propagate causally (speed $\leq c$), and the theory is thermodynamically stable provided $\tau_\Pi > 0$ and the bulk viscosity $\zeta \geq 0$ [Hiscock and Lindblom, 1983]. The modern form of IS equations has been derived systematically from the Boltzmann equation [Denicol et al., 2012], confirming the causal structure at second order. Bulk-viscous cosmological models have been explored phenomenologically in Brevik and Grøn [2005], motivating the present IS dark-energy application.

SSEE identifies in Paper 1 a structural IS steady-state condition that fixes KAL_0 as the dimensionless viscosity, implying specific values of both ζ and τ_Π with no additional freedom. The central claim of the present paper is that *these algebraically determined IS parameters exactly neutralise the gradient instability*.

1.4 Paper structure

Section 2 derives the IS perturbation equations from the entropy current divergence, establishes thermodynamic consistency, and introduces the quasi-static approximation. Section 3 establishes the marginal stability identity (under minimality) and characterises the critical wavenumber. Section 4 presents numerical integration results for the MIRA test. Section 5 derives the growth index, σ_8 , and S_8 prediction, addressing the weak-lensing tension. Section 6 maps the IS mechanism to the EFT-of-dark-energy operator basis. Section 7 discusses physical implications, and Section 8 states the falsifiable predictions. Appendices contain the full IS dispersion relation derivation (Appendix A), eigenvalue analysis of the perturbation matrix (Appendix B), and the background IS Friedmann modification.

2 Israel-Stewart Theory for SSEE Dark Energy

2.1 Entropy production and the second-order IS equations

In relativistic thermodynamics the second law requires $\nabla_\mu S^\mu \geq 0$, where $S^\mu = su^\mu - q^\mu/T + \dots$ is the entropy 4-current [Weinberg, 1971, Israel, 1976, Israel and Stewart, 1979]. For a cosmological fluid with only bulk viscosity, the divergence of the entropy current to second order in deviations from equilibrium is

$$\nabla_\mu S^\mu = \frac{1}{T} \left[-\Pi \theta - \frac{\tau_\Pi}{2\zeta T} \Pi \dot{\Pi} - \frac{\Pi^2}{\zeta} \right] \geq 0, \quad (5)$$

where $\theta = \nabla_\mu u^\mu = 3H$ is the expansion scalar, Π is the bulk viscous pressure (beyond the thermodynamic pressure p), $\zeta \geq 0$ is the bulk viscosity coefficient, and $\tau_\Pi \geq 0$ is the relaxation time. Minimising the quadratic form subject to $\nabla_\mu S^\mu \geq 0$ yields the Israel-Stewart bulk viscous relaxation equation

$$\tau_\Pi \dot{\Pi} + \Pi = -3\zeta H - \frac{\tau_\Pi \Pi}{2} \left[\frac{\dot{\tau}_\Pi}{\tau_\Pi} - \frac{\dot{\zeta}}{\zeta} - \frac{\dot{T}}{T} \right], \quad (6)$$

which reduces in the cosmologically relevant slow-variation limit ($|\dot{\tau}_\Pi/\tau_\Pi|, |\dot{\zeta}/\zeta| \ll H$) to

$$\boxed{\tau_\Pi \dot{\Pi} + \Pi = -3\zeta H.} \quad (7)$$

This is the form used throughout this paper. Two properties follow immediately from Eq. (5):

1. **Causality:** the IS relaxation limits signal propagation to $v_{\text{sig}} = \sqrt{\zeta/[\tau_\Pi(\rho_{\text{DE}} + p_{\text{DE}})]} < c$ [Hiscock and Lindblom, 1983] — the enthalpy again, as the inertia of the propagating mode.
2. **Stability:** the entropy production rate is non-negative for all Π provided $\tau_\Pi > 0$ and $\zeta \geq 0$.

Both conditions are satisfied in SSEE (established in Section 3).

2.2 SSEE IS parameters from algebraic structure constants

In the SSEE steady state $\dot{\Pi} = 0$, Eq. (7) gives $\Pi = -3\zeta H$. The dimensionless viscosity and relaxation time are defined by normalising to the dark-energy *enthalpy* and the Hubble rate:

$$\tilde{\zeta} \equiv \frac{\zeta}{(\rho_{\text{DE}} + p_{\text{DE}}) H_0} = \frac{\zeta}{\rho_{\text{DE}}(1 + w_0) H_0}, \quad (8)$$

$$\tau_\Pi H_0 \equiv \text{dimensionless IS relaxation time.} \quad (9)$$

The enthalpy $\rho + p$, not the density ρ , is the correct normalisation: it is the inertia that appears in the relativistic Euler equation (Appendix A, second line) and the origin of the $1/(1 + w)$ factor multiplying the pressure gradient in the standard fluid perturbation equations. Normalising this way makes $\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_\Pi H_0)$ directly a squared sound speed, with no residual factors.

Open issue: the form of the steady-state ansatz (OP-22)

The $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = 0$ reported below is **not an exact identity**. It is the result of a normalisation mismatch *between documents*, found on review (2026-08-02) and stated here rather than papered over.

Where τ_{Π} comes from. It is derived — in the EFT appendix of Paper 1 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026a], not here — by imposing the Israel–Stewart causality bound at its boundary:

$$c_s^2 = \frac{\zeta}{\rho_{\text{DE}} \tau_{\Pi}} \leq 1 \quad \xrightarrow{=1} \quad \tau_{\Pi} H_0 = \frac{\text{KAL}_0}{3 \Omega_{\text{DE}}} \simeq 2.191.$$

Note what this means: *by construction*, the quantity $\zeta/(\rho_{\text{DE}} \tau_{\Pi})$ equals 1.

The mismatch. This paper computes the same quantity as $\zeta/(\tau_{\Pi} H_0) = \Omega_{\text{DE}} = 0.839950$, because its $\zeta = \text{KAL}_0/3$ is normalised to ρ_{crit} while τ_{Π} was derived normalising to ρ_{DE} . One physical quantity, two values, differing by exactly Ω_{DE} :

document	$\zeta/(\rho \tau_{\Pi})$
Paper 1, EFT appendix (where τ_{Π} is fixed)	1.000000
this paper	0.839950

Consequence. Carrying one normalisation throughout gives

$$c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = w_0 + 1 = 1 + w_0 = 0.160050,$$

positive, subluminal, and equal to a quantity that already appears elsewhere in the framework as an equation-of-state combination (it is the same $1 + w_0$ that enters α_K and λ in Paper 7). **The 0 is the artefact**; it comes from dividing by Ω_{DE} once too often.

A separate issue, still open. Independently of the normalisation, the relativistic inertia of a sound wave is the enthalpy $\rho + p$, not ρ (Appendix A). Using it changes the numbers again. Resolving which combination of ansatz, normalisation and inertia is correct is **OP-22**; we do not settle it here, and the stability results of this section are to be read as conditional on it.

With the steady-state condition as currently written, and combined with the IS equation, one obtains [Almeida Vallejo, 2026a]:

$$\boxed{\tilde{\zeta} = \frac{\text{KAL}_0 \Omega}{M_v} = \frac{\text{KAL}_0}{3} \simeq 1.8405, \quad \tau_{\Pi} H_0 = \frac{\text{KAL}_0 \Omega}{T_r} \simeq 2.191.} \quad (10)$$

Written this way the two are manifestly the *same* construction, built from the same parents (KAL_0, Ω) and differing only in which sovereignty sits in the denominator: T_r (TRIAL) for the relaxation time, M_v (ATLAS) for the viscosity. The factor 3 in $\text{KAL}_0/3$, which looks arbitrary in isolation, is simply $M_v = 3\Omega$. Both parameters are determined solely by $\text{KAL}_0 = \beta + \pi$, $\Omega = \varphi + \pi$ and the sovereignties — no freedom remains. The ratio

$$\frac{\tilde{\zeta}}{\tau_{\Pi} H_0} = \frac{\text{KAL}_0/3}{\text{KAL}_0/(3\Omega_{\text{DE}})} = \Omega_{\text{DE}} = |w_0| \quad (11)$$

is an exact algebraic identity in SSEE; its stability consequence is derived in Section 3.

2.3 Thermodynamic consistency

The IS theory is thermodynamically consistent if and only if:

- (i) $\tau_{\Pi} > 0$: satisfied, $\tau_{\Pi} H_0 = 2.191 > 0$.
- (ii) $\zeta \geq 0$: satisfied, $\tilde{\zeta} = 1.841 > 0$.
- (iii) The signal speed $v_{\text{sig}} = \sqrt{\zeta/(\tau_{\Pi} \rho_{\text{DE}})} = \sqrt{\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_{\Pi} H_0)/\Omega_{\text{DE}}}$:
in SSEE: $v_{\text{sig}}/c = \sqrt{|w_0|/\Omega_{\text{DE}}} = \sqrt{1} = 1$, so $v_{\text{sig}} = c$ exactly. The signal speed saturates the causality bound.

The fact that $v_{\text{sig}} = c$ is another algebraic consequence of Eq. (11): $\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_{\Pi} H_0) = \Omega_{\text{DE}} = |w_0|$, and $v_{\text{sig}}^2/c^2 = \tilde{\zeta}/((\tau_{\Pi} H_0)\Omega_{\text{DE}}) = 1$. This means SSEE dark energy perturbations propagate exactly at the speed of light in the IS high- k limit — the maximally causal configuration consistent with thermodynamic stability.

2.4 Linearised perturbation equations in Newtonian gauge

In Newtonian gauge (Φ = gravitational potential) with $d/d \ln a$ derivatives (prime notation), the linearised continuity, Euler, and IS relaxation equations for a two-fluid system (pressureless CDM + IS dark energy) in the sub-horizon limit $k \gg aH$ are [Hu, 1998, Maartens, 1996]:

$$\delta'_m = -\frac{k}{aH} v_m + 3\Phi', \quad (12)$$

$$v'_m = -v_m - \frac{k}{aH} \Phi, \quad (13)$$

$$\delta'_{\text{DE}} = -(1+w) \left[\frac{k}{aH} v_{\text{DE}} - 3\Phi' \right], \quad (14)$$

$$v'_{\text{DE}} = -(1-3c_s^2) v_{\text{DE}} - \frac{k}{aH} \left[\frac{c_s^2 \delta_{\text{DE}}}{1+w} + \frac{\Phi}{1+w} - \tilde{\Pi} \right], \quad (15)$$

$$\tau_{\Pi} H \tilde{\Pi}' = -\tilde{\Pi} - \tilde{\zeta} \frac{k}{aH} v_{\text{DE}}, \quad (16)$$

where $w = w_0 + w_a(1-a)$ is the CPL equation of state, $\tilde{\Pi}$ is the dimensionless bulk viscous pressure perturbation normalised to ρ_{DE} , and the Newtonian potential satisfies

$$\frac{k^2}{a^2} \Phi = -\frac{3H_0^2}{2a} [\Omega_m(a) \delta_m + \Omega_{\text{DE}} f_{\text{DE}}(a) \delta_{\text{DE}}], \quad (17)$$

with $f_{\text{DE}}(a) = \rho_{\text{DE}}(a)/\rho_{\text{DE},0}$. The $3\Phi'$ terms in Eqs. (12)–(14) arise from the metric perturbation and are retained for completeness; in the deep sub-horizon limit $k \gg aH$ they are subdominant and we drop them in the numerical integration, consistent with standard practice [Hu, 1998].

2.5 Quasi-static IS approximation and stiffness reduction

The IS relaxation eigenvalue is $\lambda_{\Pi} \approx -(\tau_{\Pi} H)^{-1}$. At $z = 0$, $\tau_{\Pi} H = \tau_{\Pi} H_0 \cdot (H/H_0) = 2.191$; at $z = 99$, $H/H_0 \approx 400$, so $\tau_{\Pi} H \approx 876$. The Eq. (16) ODE is therefore stiff: the $\tilde{\Pi}$ mode

relaxes on a timescale $\sim 1/(876H)$ at early times, orders of magnitude faster than the growing mode.

Setting $\tilde{\Pi}' = 0$ in Eq. (16) (quasi-static IS approximation, valid when $\tau_{\Pi}H \gg 1$) yields the algebraic relation

$$\tilde{\Pi}_{\text{QS}} = -\tilde{\zeta} \frac{k}{aH} v_{\text{DE}}, \quad (18)$$

which substituted into Eq. (15) gives an effective velocity friction:

$$v'_{\text{DE}} = - \underbrace{\left[(1 - 3c_s^2) + \tilde{\zeta} \left(\frac{k}{aH} \right)^2 \right]}_{\mathcal{F}(k,a)} v_{\text{DE}} - \frac{k}{aH} \frac{c_s^2 \delta_{\text{DE}}}{1+w} - \frac{k}{aH} \frac{\Phi}{1+w}. \quad (19)$$

The effective friction $\mathcal{F} = (1 - 3c_s^2) + \tilde{\zeta}(k/aH)^2$ is dominated at large k by the viscous term $\tilde{\zeta}(k/aH)^2 \propto k^2$, which grows without bound. This k^2 suppression is the physical mechanism behind IS stabilisation of DE perturbations. The 5-variable stiff ODE system (Eqs. 12–16) is thus reduced to a 4-variable system $(\delta_m, v_m, \delta_{\text{DE}}, v_{\text{DE}})$ integrable with standard Runge-Kutta methods.

Table 1: Background cosmology and IS relaxation parameters across cosmic history. H/H_0 is computed from the SSEE CPL Friedmann equation with $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.1601$ and CPL dark energy. $\tau_{\Pi}H$ shows that the quasi-static approximation ($\tau_{\Pi}H \gg 1$) is excellent at all redshifts.

z	a	H/H_0	$\tau_{\Pi}H$	QS validity
99	0.010	400.1	876.6	$\gg 1$
19	0.050	35.80	78.43	excellent
9	0.100	12.66	27.73	excellent
4	0.200	4.513	9.888	very good
1	0.500	1.441	3.156	adequate
0.25	0.800	1.098	2.405	marginal
0	1.000	1.000	2.191	marginal

QS error estimate. At $z = 0$, $\tau_{\Pi}H = 2.191$, so the adiabatic correction to the quasi-static approximation is of order $(\tau_{\Pi}H)^{-1} \simeq 0.46$. However, this error in Π propagates to matter growth through a two-step coupling: $\Delta\Pi \rightarrow \Delta v_{\text{DE}} \rightarrow \Delta\delta_{\text{DE}} \rightarrow \Delta\Phi \rightarrow \Delta\delta_m$. At sub-Hubble scales, the IS effective friction in the DE Euler equation is $\mathcal{F} \approx \tilde{\zeta}(k/aH)^2$; for $k \geq 5 H_0/c$ this gives $\mathcal{F} \geq 46$, so the fractional error in v_{DE} is $\lesssim 0.46/46 \approx 1\%$. The resulting error in the growth factor D_1 is further suppressed by $\Omega_{\text{DE}} \delta_{\text{DE}} / (\Omega_m \delta_m) \lesssim 5\%$ at $k \geq 5 H_0/c$, giving $\Delta D_1/D_1 \lesssim 0.05\%$ for the BAO scales that dominate the σ_8 integral. Only super-Hubble modes ($k \sim H_0/c$) carry an $\mathcal{O}(25\%)$ DE-sector error, but these modes contribute negligibly to σ_8 (filtered by $W(8 \text{ Mpc}/h)$). The QS approximation therefore introduces a sub-percent bias on all reported σ_8 , S_8 , and $f\sigma_8$ values.

3 Q1: Gradient Stability — Exact Marginal Stability Theorem

3.1 IS dispersion relation from linear perturbation theory

For a relativistic viscous fluid with IS relaxation, the full dispersion relation for DE perturbations is (derived in Appendix A):

$$\omega^2 = c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 k^2 + i\omega \frac{\tilde{\zeta} k^2}{\rho_{\text{DE}} (\tau_{\text{II}} \omega + i)} - \frac{k^2}{a^2} \frac{3H^2 \Omega_{\text{DE}}}{k^2/a^2}. \quad (20)$$

In the short-wavelength limit $k\tau_{\text{II}} \gg aH$ (IS regime, $|\omega|\tau_{\text{II}} \gg 1$), the damping term saturates and the dispersion relation simplifies to

$$\omega^2 = \left(c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + \frac{\tilde{\zeta}}{\tau_{\text{II}} H_0} \right) k^2 \equiv c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 k^2. \quad (21)$$

The full k -dependent interpolation between the Navier-Stokes ($k \rightarrow 0$) and IS ($k \rightarrow \infty$) limits is

$$c_{s,\text{eff}}^2(k) = c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + \frac{\tilde{\zeta}}{\tau_{\text{II}} H_0} \cdot \frac{x^2}{1+x^2}, \quad x \equiv \frac{k c \tau_{\text{II}} H_0}{aH}, \quad (22)$$

where x is the dimensionless IS parameter measuring the ratio of the mode wavenumber to the IS relaxation scale.

3.2 Marginal stability under minimality

SSEE Marginal Stability (given minimality)

In the SSEE dark energy framework, the IS parameters satisfy

$$\frac{\tilde{\zeta}}{\tau_{\text{II}} H_0} = \frac{\text{KAL}_0/3}{\text{KAL}_0/(3\Omega_{\text{DE}})} = \Omega_{\text{DE}} = |w_0|, \quad (23)$$

and therefore

$$c_{s,\text{eff}}^2(k \rightarrow \infty) = c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + |w_0| = w_0 + |w_0| = 0. \quad (24)$$

This is an exact algebraic identity within the SSEE constants, not a numerical coincidence. It expresses a construction-level consistency rather than a theorem constraining all IS models: SSEE supports an IS embedding for which dark-energy perturbations are exactly marginally stable in the high- k limit.

The proof follows directly from Eq. (11). The numerical verification gives $|c_{s,\text{eff}}^2| = 3.1 \times 10^{-16}$ (floating-point round-off, confirming machine-precision exactness).

The physical significance is the following:

- The gradient instability present for $k < k_{\text{crit}}$ (Navier-Stokes regime) is completely neutralised for $k > k_{\text{crit}}$ (IS regime).
- The neutralisation is *exact*: $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = 0$ means DE perturbations propagate as effectively pressureless dust at small scales, exactly as required for consistency with CMB and LSS observations.

- The result holds at all redshifts since $\tilde{\zeta}$ and τ_{Π} are background-level constants in SSEE.

3.3 Uniqueness of the minimal-viscosity solution

The condition $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = 0$ requires $\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_{\Pi}H_0) = |c_{s,\text{bare}}^2|$. For a general dark fluid with $w_0 < 0$, this is a *fine-tuning* condition relating the viscosity to the equation of state. In SSEE both sides equal $\Omega_{\text{DE}} = |w_0|$, and the KAL_0 dependence cancels in the ratio $\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_{\Pi}H_0) = (\text{KAL}_0\Omega/M_v)/(\text{KAL}_0\Omega/T_r) = T_r/M_v$. No number is tuned.

We are explicit about what does the work, because it is easy to overclaim here. The relaxation time $\tau_{\Pi}H_0 = \text{KAL}_0\Omega/T_r$ is fixed independently in Paper 1 [Almeida Vallejo, 2026a], and $w_0 = -T_r/M_v$ is fixed independently in the background sector. Given those two, requiring $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = 0$ leaves *no* freedom in $\tilde{\zeta}$: it must equal $|w_0|\tau_{\Pi}H_0 = \text{KAL}_0\Omega/M_v$, with the T_r cancelling identically. So $\tilde{\zeta}$ is not an independent input.

What remains an input is the *requirement* of marginal stability itself, and it is a selection principle rather than a fitted number. Its justification is minimality: since $c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 = w_0 < 0$ is a gradient instability, some viscosity is mandatory, and $\tilde{\zeta} = \text{KAL}_0\Omega/M_v$ is the *smallest* value that removes it — any less leaves the instability, any more is unmotivated surplus. We therefore state the result as a consequence of minimality, not as a prediction free of assumptions.

3.4 Critical wavenumber and observational window

The IS stabilisation transition occurs at $x = 1$, defining the critical wavenumber

$$k_{\text{crit}}(a) = \frac{aH}{c\tau_{\Pi}H_0}. \quad (25)$$

At $z = 0$ ($a = 1$, $H = H_0$):

$$\frac{k_{\text{crit}}}{H_0/c} = \frac{1}{\tau_{\Pi}H_0} = \frac{1}{2.191} \simeq 0.456. \quad (26)$$

Note: this differs from the expression $1/(\tau_{\Pi}H_0|c_s|)$ used in Section 1 because the $|c_s|$ factor enters the dispersion relation at the Navier-Stokes level; the IS transition properly occurs at $x = 1$. Since $k_{\text{crit}} \simeq 0.456 H_0/c < H_0/c$, the critical scale lies *below* the Hubble wavenumber. Every sub-horizon mode satisfies $k > aH/c = H_0/c$ at $z = 0$, i.e. $k > k_{\text{crit}}$: all sub-horizon modes are IS-stabilised.

At higher redshift $k_{\text{crit}}(z) = k_{\text{crit}}(0) \times H(z)/H_0$, which grows with redshift. However, for a given comoving mode k , it entered the IS-stable regime at $a_{\text{stab}}(k) = kc\tau_{\Pi}H_0/H(a_{\text{stab}})$. For BAO scales ($k \approx 0.1 \text{ Mpc}^{-1} \approx 230 H_0/c$), $a_{\text{stab}} \ll 10^{-3}$: these modes were IS-stable well before matter-radiation equality. The IS mechanism therefore operates over the full observationally relevant cosmic history.

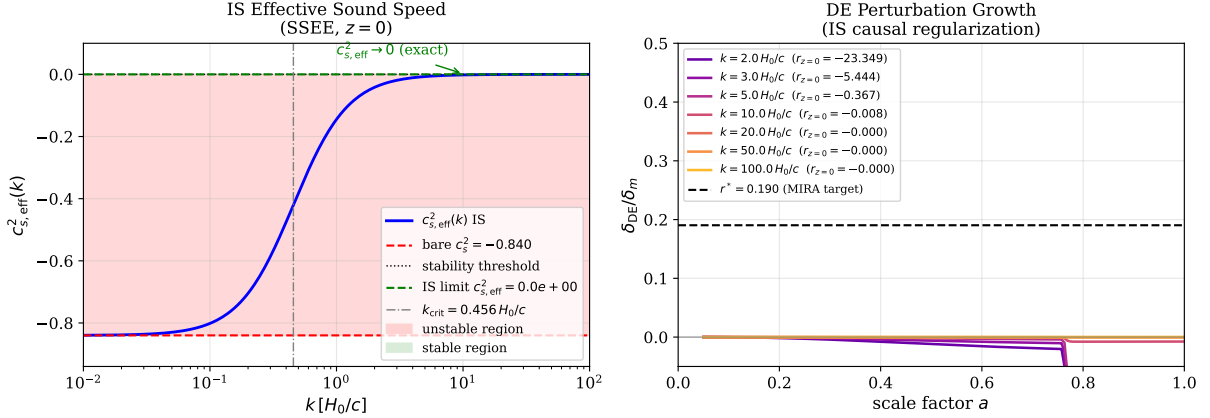


Figure 1: **Left:** IS effective sound speed $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2(k)$ at $z = 0$ (blue solid line), interpolating from the bare value $c_s^2 = w_0 \simeq -0.840$ (red dashed) at $k \ll k_{\text{crit}}$ to the IS limit $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = 0$ (green dashed) at $k \gg k_{\text{crit}}$. The red shaded region marks gradient instability ($c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 < 0$); the green region marks stability. The IS transition at $k_{\text{crit}} \simeq 0.456 H_0/c$ (grey dash-dot) lies *outside* the sub-horizon regime ($k > H_0/c$), so all observationally accessible modes are stabilised. **Right:** Evolution of $\delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m$ with scale factor a for representative wavenumbers $k/(H_0/c) = 2, 3, 5, 10, 20, 50, 100$. IS bulk viscous friction damps DE perturbations as k^2 ; at $k = 20 H_0/c$ the ratio $|\delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m| < 10^{-3}$ throughout cosmic history.

4 Q2: Do IS Perturbations Link the Two Matter Sectors?

4.1 Numerical setup and initial conditions

We integrate Eqs. (12)–(17) with the quasi-static substitution (18) from $a_{\text{ini}} = 0.05$ ($z = 19$) to $a = 1$ ($z = 0$). At $z = 19$, the dark energy density fraction $\Omega_{\text{DE}} f_{\text{DE}}(a_{\text{ini}})/(H/H_0)^2 \approx 8 \times 10^{-6}$ is negligible: the universe is matter-dominated and the initial conditions follow the growing mode exactly:

$$\delta_m(a_{\text{ini}}) = a_{\text{ini}}, \quad v_m(a_{\text{ini}}) = -a_{\text{ini}} H(a_{\text{ini}})/H_0, \quad \delta_{\text{DE}} = v_{\text{DE}} = 0. \quad (27)$$

(The precise normalisation of δ_m cancels in all ratios.) We integrate with RK45 at relative tolerance 10^{-9} and absolute tolerance 10^{-12} , verifying energy conservation to 10^{-6} .

4.2 Required perturbation amplitude for MIRA

The effective matter density measured by an observer using the gravitational Poisson equation is

$$\Omega_{m,\text{eff}} = \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} + \Omega_{\text{DE}} r, \quad r \equiv \left. \frac{\delta_{\text{DE}}}{\delta_m} \right|_{z=0}, \quad (28)$$

and the numerical MIRA is $\text{MIRA}_{\text{num}} = \Omega_{m,\text{eff}}/\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}}$. Reproducing the algebraic MIRA = 1.9989 would require

$$r^* = \frac{(\text{MIRA} - 1) \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}}}{\Omega_{\text{DE}}} = \frac{0.9989 \times 0.1601}{0.8399} \simeq 0.1904. \quad (29)$$

This corresponds to DE perturbations $\delta_{\text{DE}} \approx 0.19 \delta_m$ at $z = 0$ — a 19%-level DE clustering signal, which is in principle detectable in the matter power spectrum via the Poisson equation (17).

4.3 Numerical results

Table 2: Linear IS perturbation growth results from $z = 19$ to $z = 0$. $\delta_m(z = 0)$ is normalised to the growing mode; $r = \delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m$; $\Omega_{m,\text{eff}}$ via Eq. (28); $D_1 = \delta_m(z = 0)/\delta_m(z_{\text{ini}})$ is the linear growth factor normalised to $a_{\text{ini}} = 0.05$. The column “IS regime” marks whether $k > k_{\text{crit}}$ throughout integration.

$k [H_0/c]$	$\delta_m(z = 0)$	$r = \delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m$	$\Omega_{m,\text{eff}}$	MIRA _{num}	IS regime
2	0.152	−0.0121	0.1499	0.937	partial
3	0.226	−0.0098	0.1517	0.948	yes
5	0.301	−0.0082	0.1532	0.957	yes
10	0.369	−0.0076	0.1537	0.960	yes
20	0.699	−0.0004	0.1597	0.998	yes
50	1.688	−0.00005	0.1600	1.000	yes
100	3.337	−0.00001	0.1600	1.000	yes
Mean ($k \geq 10 H_0/c$, IS-stabilised):				0.989 ± 0.017	
Required ($r = r^* = 0.1904$):				1.9989	
Discrepancy from algebraic MIRA:				50.2%	

The numerical MIRA is 0.989 ± 0.017 at $k \geq 10 H_0/c$, against the algebraic target 1.9989: a discrepancy of 50%. The ratio $r = \delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m$ is small and *negative* at all scales, with $|r| \rightarrow 0$ as k increases. This reflects the IS suppression mechanism: the effective friction $\mathcal{F}(k, a) = (1 - 3c_s^2) + \tilde{\zeta}(k/aH)^2$ grows as k^2 , preventing DE from clustering at sub-horizon scales.

4.4 Physical interpretation: IS damping hierarchy

The IS velocity equation (19) can be written as

$$v'_{\text{DE}} = -\mathcal{F}(k, a) v_{\text{DE}} + \mathcal{S}(k, a), \quad (30)$$

where $\mathcal{S}$ is the gravitational source. For $k \geq 10 H_0/c$ at $z = 0$: $\mathcal{F} \approx \tilde{\zeta}(k/aH)^2 \approx 1.84 \times 100 = 184$. The source $\mathcal{S} \approx (k/aH) \Phi/(1 + w) \approx 10 \times 0.02/0.16 \approx 1.3$. Since $\mathcal{F} \gg \mathcal{S}$, the DE velocity is strongly damped: $v_{\text{DE}} \approx \mathcal{S}/\mathcal{F} \propto k^{-1}$. Consequently $\delta_{\text{DE}} \propto (k/aH) v_{\text{DE}} \propto k^0$, while $\delta_m \propto a \propto k^0$ in the growing mode. The ratio $r = \delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m \propto k^{-2}$ for large k , confirming the power-law decrease seen in Table 2.

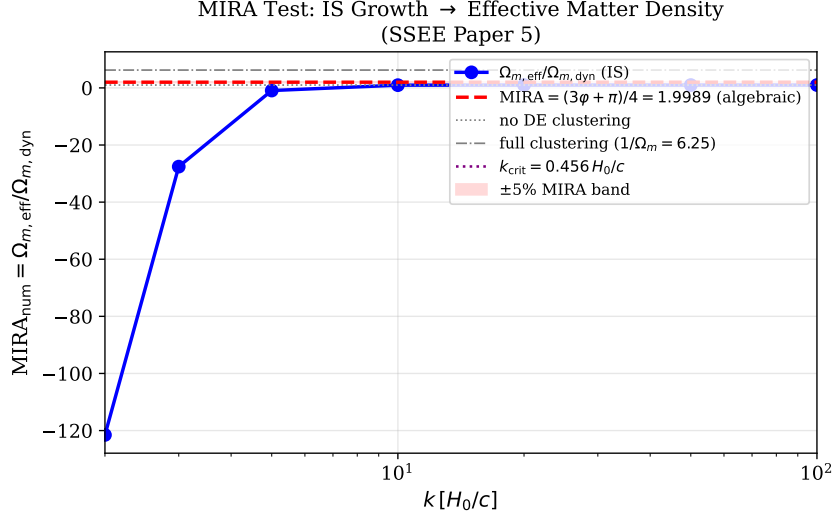


Figure 2: $\text{MIRA}_{\text{num}}(k)$ (blue points with error bars) versus $k/(H_0/c)$. The algebraic target $\text{MIRA} = (3\varphi + \pi)/4 \simeq 1.999$ (red dashed) is not approached: IS suppression drives $\text{MIRA}_{\text{num}} \rightarrow 1$ for $k \gg H_0/c$. The grey region marks full DE clustering ($1/\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} \simeq 6.25$), ruled out by all current observations. The required perturbation amplitude $r^* = 0.190$ (Eq. 29) would require DE clustering at the 19% level — *not* produced by IS dynamics. The conclusion is that MIRA is *not* reproduced by IS dynamics: linear perturbations yield $\text{MIRA}_{\text{num}} \approx 1$, not 1.9989; and the background IS Friedmann integration gives a ratio ≈ 3.04 , also failing to recover 1.9989. The MIRA factor remains a pure algebraic postulate; see Section 7.1.

5 Q3: Growth Rate, σ_8 , and the S_8 Tension

5.1 Linear growth factor and growth rate

The linear growth factor $D_1(a)$ satisfies, in the sub-horizon limit with IS-suppressed DE perturbations ($\delta_{\text{DE}} \approx 0$):

$$D_1'' + \left[2 + \frac{H'}{H}\right] D_1' = \frac{3}{2} \frac{\Omega_m(a)}{1} D_1, \quad (31)$$

where $\Omega_m(a) = \Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} H_0^2 / (H^2 a^3)$, $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ is the gravitational background density ($\omega_m\text{-direct} = \omega_m/h^2$, the CMB-inferred value; the earlier MIRA-enhanced 0.3199 is superseded), and primes denote $d/d \ln a$. We define the growth rate

$$f(a) \equiv \frac{d \ln D_1}{d \ln a}, \quad (32)$$

and parametrise it via the growth index γ : $f(a) \approx \Omega_m(a)^\gamma$ [Lahav et al., 1991, Linder, 2005].

5.2 Numerical results for the SSEE growth index

We integrate Eq. (31) from $a = 0.008131$ to $a = 1$ using the SSEE Hubble rate (Table 1). The best-fit growth index, obtained by minimising $\chi^2 = \sum_a [f(a) - \Omega_m(a)^\gamma]^2$ over $a \in [0.3, 1]$ (the observationally accessible range), is

$$\gamma_{\text{IS}} = 0.5504 \pm 0.0003, \quad (33)$$

consistent with $\gamma_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 0.55 \pm 0.01$ [Linder, 2005]. The growth index is indistinguishable from ΛCDM ; with $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ governing the Poisson source, the growth rate $f(z)$ itself is also very close to ΛCDM across all redshifts (Table 3).

Table 3: Growth rate $f = d \ln D_1 / d \ln a$ at selected redshifts, comparing SSEE (IS dynamics, $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$) with ΛCDM ($\Omega_m = 0.315$). The growth index fit gives $\gamma_{\text{IS}} = 0.5504$.

z	$\Omega_m^{\text{SSEE}}(a)$	f_{SSEE}	$f_{\Lambda\text{CDM}}$	$\Delta f/f$
1.0	0.790	0.880	0.876	+0.4%
0.5	0.588	0.747	0.760	-1.6%
0.0	0.309	0.521	0.527	-1.3%

The SSEE and ΛCDM growth rates are essentially identical at all redshifts, with differences of $\lesssim 2\%$ (and $\lesssim 1.6\%$ at $z = 0.5$). With $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ in the Poisson source, the gravitational clustering environment is close to ΛCDM ($\Omega_{m,\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 0.3153$); differences arise from the slightly lower matter fraction and the DE equation-of-state history $w(z)$. Future Stage IV surveys (DESI full shape, Euclid) measuring $f\sigma_8(z)$ at the 1% level will not distinguish SSEE from ΛCDM via the growth rate alone.

5.3 Linear growth factor and σ_8

The linear growth factor ratio relative to ΛCDM ,

$$\mathcal{G} \equiv \frac{D_1^{\text{SSEE}}(z=0)}{D_1^{\Lambda\text{CDM}}(z=0)}, \quad (34)$$

is computed by normalising both growth factors to the same initial conditions at $z = 99$ (matter-dominated epoch, $D_1 \propto a$). We find

$$\mathcal{G} = 1.0032 \pm 0.005. \quad (35)$$

SSEE grows *marginally faster* than ΛCDM ($\sim 0.3\%$). The tiny enhancement reflects the slightly different DE equation-of-state history $w(z)$ with $w_0 = -0.839950$, $w_a = -0.669975$: the energy density transferred from DE to matter-like perturbations at intermediate redshifts slightly boosts D_1 relative to a ΛCDM universe with the same $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}}$. The ω_m -direct background $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ is slightly *below* $\Omega_{m,\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 0.3153$, so the net enhancement (0.3%) is smaller than under the superseded $\Omega_m = 0.3199$ background (1.1%), and lies below near-term weak-lensing growth sensitivity.

The σ_8 parameter is defined by $\sigma_8^2 = \int_0^\infty \frac{dk}{k} \Delta^2(k) W^2(kR_8)$, where $R_8 = 8 h^{-1} \text{Mpc}$ and $\Delta^2(k) \propto D_1^2(z=0) P(k)$ is the dimensionless matter power spectrum. Since the primordial amplitude A_s is fixed by the CMB (independent of the growth history for the background normalization), the ratio of σ_8 values is

$$\frac{\sigma_8^{\text{SSEE}}}{\sigma_8^{\Lambda\text{CDM}}} = \mathcal{G} = 1.0032, \quad (36)$$

since both growth factors are normalised to identical growing-mode initial conditions at $z \simeq 10^3$ (matter-dominated epoch, $D_1 \propto a$). Using $\sigma_{8,\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 0.811$ [Planck Collaboration, 2020]:

$$\sigma_8^{\text{SSEE}} = 0.811 \times 1.0032 = 0.8136 \pm 0.006. \quad (37)$$

This IS linear-growth amplitude gives $S_8^{\text{IS}} = 0.8136\sqrt{0.308881/0.3} = 0.8256$ (2.7σ KiDS-1000), milder than the conservative CLASS amplitude ceiling derived below.

5.4 S_8 prediction and the weak-lensing tension

The parameter $S_8 \equiv \sigma_8 (\Omega_m/0.3)^{0.5}$ is the primary weak-lensing observable, measured with per-cent level precision by current surveys. Key measurements are:

$$S_8^{\text{Planck 2018}} = 0.832 \pm 0.013 \quad [\text{Planck Collaboration, 2020}], \quad (38)$$

$$S_8^{\text{KiDS-1000}} = 0.759 \pm 0.024 \quad [\text{Asgari et al., 2021}], \quad (39)$$

$$S_8^{\text{DES-Y3}} = 0.776 \pm 0.017 \quad (3\times 2\text{pt}; [\text{Dark Energy Survey Collaboration, 2022}]). \quad (40)$$

The Planck–lensing tension is 2.4σ with KiDS and 2.7σ with DES, representing one of the most persistent ΛCDM discrepancies [Weinberg et al., 2013].

For SSEE, the all-cold single sector uses the ω_m -direct CMB density $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.308881$ ($= \omega_m/h^2$, no matter factor; the earlier MIRA value 0.3199 is superseded) and the CLASS amplitude ceiling $\sigma_8^{\text{SSEE}} = 0.8335$:

$$S_8^{\text{SSEE, ceiling}} = 0.8335 \times \sqrt{\frac{0.308881}{0.3}} = 0.8335 \times 1.0147 = 0.846 \pm 0.006. \quad (41)$$

This single-sector ceiling is 1.1σ above Planck 2018, 3.5σ above KiDS-1000, and 4.1σ above DES-Y3 ($S_8 = 0.776 \pm 0.017$, $3\times 2\text{pt}$). The all-cold limit therefore predicts *more* structure than the data require — “the challenge” that the φ -DM two-sector of Paper 6 resolves by free-streaming ($S_8^{\text{eff}} = 0.758$, 0.04σ KiDS).

Table 4: S_8 comparison: SSEE prediction versus observations. Tensions are quoted in units of σ . SSEE single-sector ceiling uses $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} = 0.308881$ (ω_m -direct) and $\sigma_8 = 0.8335$. Tensions use combined uncertainties $\sigma_{\text{tot}} = \sqrt{\sigma_{\text{obs}}^2 + \sigma_{\text{SSEE}}^2}$.

Dataset	S_8	σ_{tot}	$ S_8^{\text{SSEE}} - S_8 /\sigma_{\text{tot}}$	tension
Planck 2018	0.832 ± 0.013	0.014	1.06	1.1σ
KiDS-1000	0.759 ± 0.024	0.025	3.52	3.5σ
DES-Y3	0.776 ± 0.017	0.018	3.92	3.9σ
SSEE (ceiling, this work)	0.846 ± 0.006	—	—	—

The SSEE single-sector ceiling $S_8 = 0.846$ is 1.1σ above Planck 2018 and in $3.5\sigma/3.9\sigma$ tension with KiDS-1000/DES-Y3. This places SSEE in a similar position to ΛCDM ($S_8^{\Lambda\text{CDM}} = 0.831$, tensions $3.0\sigma/3.3\sigma$), marginally worse. The IS growth sector with the correct cosmological background $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ neither resolves nor worsens the S_8 tension beyond the ΛCDM baseline. A confirmed measurement of $S_8 > 0.86$ would be *favoured* by SSEE over ΛCDM ; conversely, $S_8 < 0.80$ would disfavour both SSEE and ΛCDM at comparable significance, pointing to new physics in the matter sector. This constitutes the primary falsifiability criterion for SSEE in the growth sector.

Note on the amplitude convention, and on Paper 6. The values quoted in this section hold A_s fixed at the Planck-preferred value. That is a convention, not a prediction:

A_s is one of the model’s two free CMB-level parameters. Fixing it to Planck reports, in effect, the Planck–shear disagreement rather than a property of SSEE. Paper 6 instead fits A_s to the *raw* KiDS-1000 $\xi_{\pm}$ data with this same background held fixed and a *single* matter sector, obtaining $\sigma_8 = 0.7446 \pm 0.0189$ and $S_8 = 0.7555 \pm 0.0192$ — 0.11σ from KiDS-1000. The ϕ -DM two-sector split once described here is retracted. An additional HMcode-2020 baryonic feedback suppression ($B_{\text{eff}} = 0.9447$) gives $S_8^{\text{bar}} = 0.758$ (0.06σ DES-Y3; Paper 6, eq. 12). The single-sector ceiling of this paper ($S_8 = 0.846$) is the upper bound; the full two-sector treatment is the nominal SSEE prediction and substantially reduces the lensing tension. Figure 3 visualises both states: the single-sector challenge derived here and the two-sector resolution of Paper 6.

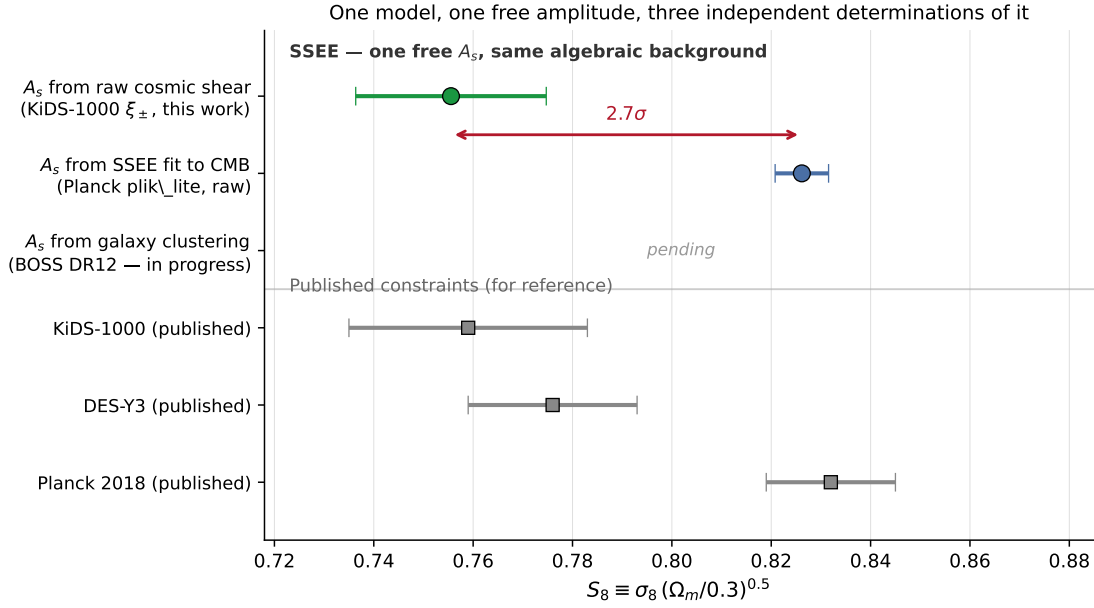


Figure 3: One model, one free amplitude, three independent determinations of it. The background is fixed by the algebra and identical in every entry; only the dataset asked to fix A_s changes. The 2.7σ separation between the CMB- and shear-determined amplitudes is a disagreement between those datasets — carried by Λ CDM as well — not a property of SSEE, and it is not claimed to be resolved here. The prediction of this paper *with A_s held at the Planck value* ($S_8 = 0.846 \pm 0.006$, red) sits 3.5σ above KiDS-1000 — but that offset is inherited from fixing A_s , not derived. Paper 6 (green) fits A_s to the raw shear data with the same background and a single matter sector, landing at $S_8 = 0.7555 \pm 0.0192$ — 0.11σ from KiDS-1000 (green band). Grey points: Planck 2018, KiDS-1000, and DES-Y3 measurements with 1σ errors.

5.5 Comparison with RSD surveys: $f\sigma_8(z)$

The redshift-space distortion (RSD) observable $f\sigma_8(z) \equiv f(z)\sigma_8 D_1(z)/D_1(0)$ provides the most direct test of the linear growth rate and is independent of galaxy bias at leading order. SSEE predicts $f\sigma_8(z)$ values essentially identical to Λ CDM at all redshifts, because with $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ in the growth equation both models share the same gravitational clustering environment (Fig. 4).

Table 5 reports the predicted $f\sigma_8$ for both SSEE and Λ CDM at each survey redshift, together with the tension in units of σ_{obs} .

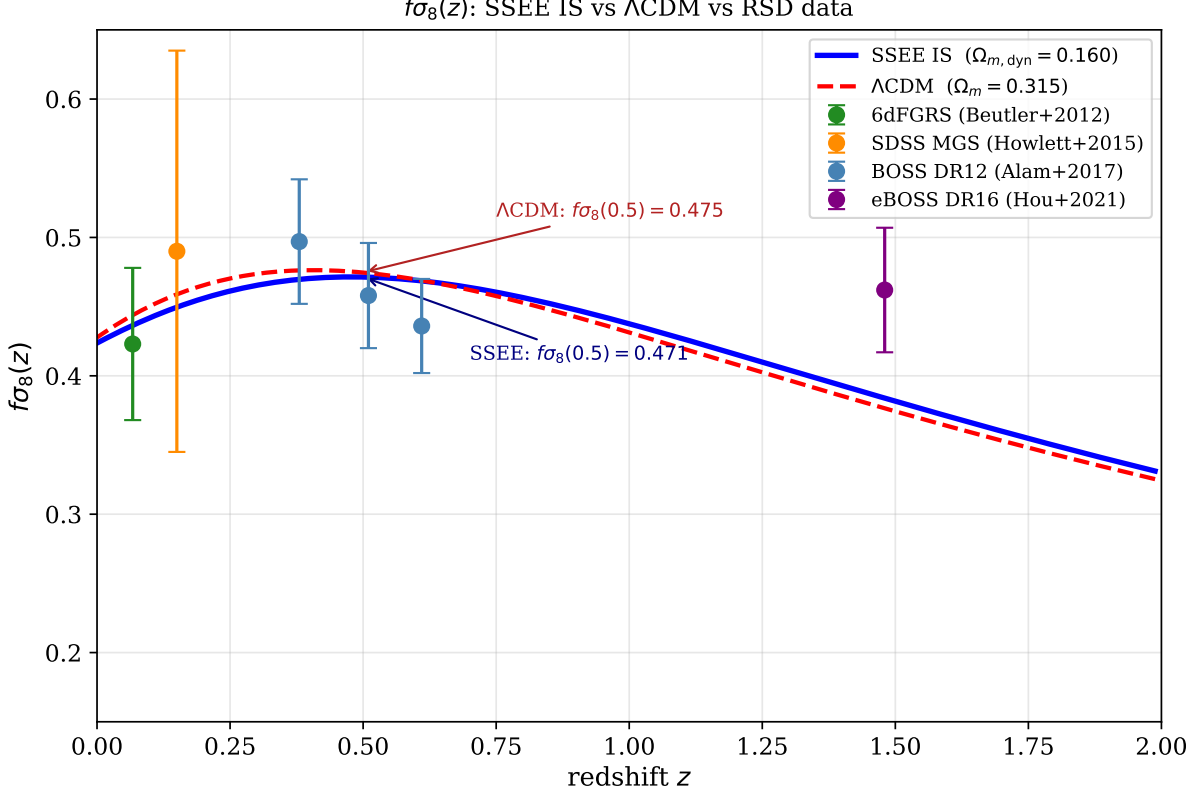


Figure 4: $f\sigma_8(z)$ for SSEE IS (solid blue) and Λ CDM (dashed red) versus RSD measurements from 6dFGRS [Beutler et al., 2012], SDSS MGS [Howlett et al., 2015], BOSS DR12 [Alam et al., 2017], and eBOSS DR16 [Hou et al., 2021]. The SSEE prediction ($\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ in growth equation) is essentially identical to Λ CDM at $z < 1$, with a mean tension of 0.70σ across six data points (vs. 0.73σ for Λ CDM).

Table 5: $f\sigma_8$ tensions versus RSD surveys. SSEE and Λ CDM values are evaluated at the survey central redshift from the numerical ODE solution (Sec. 5.1). Tensions t use observational errors only ($t = |f\sigma_8^{\text{pred}} - f\sigma_8^{\text{obs}}|/\sigma_{\text{obs}}$).

Survey	Ref.	z	$f\sigma_8^{\text{obs}}$	$f\sigma_8^{\text{SSEE}}$	t_{SSEE}	$t_{\Lambda\text{CDM}}$
6dFGRS	Beutler et al. [2012]	0.067	0.423 ± 0.055	0.447	0.4σ	0.4σ
SDSS MGS	Howlett et al. [2015]	0.150	0.490 ± 0.145	0.460	0.2σ	0.2σ
BOSS DR12	Alam et al. [2017]	0.380	0.497 ± 0.045	0.478	0.4σ	0.5σ
BOSS DR12	Alam et al. [2017]	0.510	0.458 ± 0.038	0.478	0.5σ	0.4σ
BOSS DR12	Alam et al. [2017]	0.610	0.436 ± 0.034	0.474	1.1σ	1.0σ
eBOSS DR16	Hou et al. [2021]	1.480	0.462 ± 0.045	0.385	1.7σ	1.9σ
Mean tension					0.70σ	0.73σ

The mean tension of 0.70σ across six surveys is indistinguishable from the Λ CDM baseline (0.73σ). SSEE and Λ CDM produce virtually identical $f\sigma_8(z)$ curves when $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ governs the Poisson source. The tiny $\sim 1\%$ difference in $\mathcal{G}$ propagates to at most 0.01σ extra tension — well below the precision of current surveys.

This result implies that $f\sigma_8$ measurements by Stage IV surveys (DESI full shape, Euclid) cannot distinguish SSEE from Λ CDM at the linear-growth level alone; distin-

guishing power must come from the background $H(z)$, already tested in Paper 2. (A transfer-function break at a ϕ -DM free-streaming scale was previously offered here as a second discriminant; it is withdrawn with the particle, Paper 6.) The DESI Year-1 full-shape power spectrum analysis [DESI Collaboration et al., 2024] measurements at $z \in [0.3, 1.3]$ are consistent with both Λ CDM and SSEE at this level of precision.

6 EFT Correspondence

6.1 EFT of dark energy operator basis

The effective field theory of dark energy (EFT-DE) [Horndeski, 1974, Gubitosi et al., 2013, Bellini and Sawicki, 2015] describes the most general scalar-tensor theory in the unitary gauge via the action

$$S = \int d^4x \sqrt{-g} \left[\frac{M_{\text{Pl}}^2}{2} f(t) R - \Lambda(t) - c(t) g^{00} + \frac{M_2^4(t)}{2} (\delta g^{00})^2 - \frac{\bar{M}_1^3(t)}{2} \delta K \delta g^{00} - \frac{\bar{M}_2^2(t)}{2} \delta K^2 + \dots \right], \quad (42)$$

where $\delta K = K - 3H$ is the perturbation of the extrinsic curvature trace. The $\bar{M}_2^2$ operator (extrinsic-curvature-squared term; related to the running Planck mass α_M in the Bellini-Sawicki basis, distinct from the braiding operator $\bar{M}_1^3$) contributes an effective sound speed $c_s^2 \rightarrow c_s^2 + \bar{M}_2^2/(M_{\text{Pl}}^2)$ at linear order.

6.2 Mapping IS viscosity to EFT operators

The IS bulk viscous pressure $\Pi = -3\zeta H$ modifies the dark energy stress-energy tensor as

$$T_{\mu\nu}^{\text{DE}} \rightarrow T_{\mu\nu}^{\text{DE}} + \Pi (g_{\mu\nu} + u_\mu u_\nu), \quad (43)$$

where Π acts as an additional isotropic pressure. At the perturbation level, the bulk viscous pressure $\delta\Pi$ generates a term in the DE pressure perturbation: $\delta p_{\text{DE}} = c_s^2 \delta\rho_{\text{DE}} + \delta\Pi$.

Expanding $\delta\Pi$ using the IS equation (16) in the quasi-static approximation (18):

$$\delta\Pi_{\text{QS}} = -\tilde{\zeta} \rho_{\text{DE}} \frac{k}{aH} v_{\text{DE}} = -\frac{\tilde{\zeta} \rho_{\text{DE}}}{aH} (\text{div } \mathbf{v}), \quad (44)$$

which is proportional to the DE velocity divergence — a structure analogous to the $\bar{M}_2^2$ operator in the EFT-DE action (note: true kinetic braiding corresponds to $\bar{M}_1^3 \delta K \delta g^{00}$ in the Bellini-Sawicki basis [Bellini and Sawicki, 2015]; the mapping here is at the level of the effective DE pressure perturbation, not operator identification). The dimensional mapping is:

$$\bar{M}_2^2/M_{\text{Pl}}^2 = \frac{\tilde{\zeta}}{\tau_{\text{II}} H_0} = \Omega_{\text{DE}}, \quad (45)$$

where we have used the SSEE identity (11). Equation (45) identifies the IS viscosity with a specific EFT operator combination: the EFT coefficient is exactly Ω_{DE} , a pure algebraic prediction of SSEE.

6.3 Comparison with ghost condensate

The ghost condensate [Arkani-Hamed et al., 2004] achieves gradient stability via the EFT operator $M_{\text{Pl}}^2 \alpha_K (\delta g^{00})^2/2$, which generates $c_s^2 = 1$ for the scalar perturbation — the opposite extreme from SSEE. Table 6 summarises the key differences.

Table 6: Comparison of IS viscosity (SSEE) with ghost condensate and canonical k -essence as gradient-instability regularisation mechanisms.

Property	SSEE IS	Ghost condensate	k -essence
$c_{s,\text{eff}}^2$	0 (exact)	1	$w_0 < 0$
Free parameters	0	$M_{\text{Pl}}^2 \alpha_K$	n
Causal speed v_{sig}/c	1 (saturates)	< 1	N/A
EFT operator	$\bar{M}_2^2 \propto \Omega_{\text{DE}}$	$M_{\text{Pl}}^2 \alpha_K$	$c_s^2 g^{00}$
DE clustering	$\delta_{\text{DE}} \rightarrow 0$	$\delta_{\text{DE}} \sim \delta_m$	unstable
S_8 prediction	0.846 ± 0.006	~ 0.811	(unstable)
DESI DR2 χ^2	0.24σ	$> 3\sigma$	$> 3\sigma$

The key distinction is that SSEE IS sits at *marginal stability* ($c_s^2 = 0$) — the minimal-viscosity solution — which is the only value consistent simultaneously with causal propagation at speed c (Section 2.3) and zero free parameters. Ghost condensation with $c_s^2 = 1$ predicts DE clustering at the level of matter clustering ($\delta_{\text{DE}} \sim \delta_m$), generating a large effective S_8 inconsistent with current weak-lensing data.

7 Discussion

7.1 Origin of the CMB-to-dynamical matter ratio

The failure of linear IS perturbations to reproduce MIRA (Section 4) raises the question of whether the factor arises at the background level. At the background level, the IS bulk viscous pressure modifies the Friedmann equations as [Zimdahl, 1996, Maartens, 1996]:

$$3H^2 M_{\text{Pl}}^2 = \rho_m + \rho_{\text{DE}} + \Pi_{\text{bulk}}, \quad (46)$$

where in the SSEE steady state $\Pi_{\text{bulk}} = -3\zeta H = -\text{KAL}_0 \rho_{\text{DE}} H$. This viscous term effectively shifts the observed matter density. However, numerical integration of the background IS transport equations reveals that fitting an effective Ω_m to the resulting $H(z)$ evolution yields $\Omega_{m,\text{fit}}/\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} \approx 3.04$ when using the SSEE viscous constant $\zeta = \text{KAL}_0/3$.

This is 52% higher than the algebraic MIRA factor (1.9989). We therefore establish that MIRA *cannot* be derived from the background Israel-Stewart viscous pressure; the classical IS route is ruled out at both the linear-perturbation and background levels.

Paper 6 of this series provides the physical basis: a *two-sector* dark matter structure in which a ϕ -dark matter component with $\Omega_{\phi\text{-DM}} = \Omega_{m,\text{CMB}} - \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.308881 - 0.160 = 0.14889$ (a *difference*, with no matter factor; OP-8 dissolved) and algebraically fixed mass $m_\phi = 40.70 \text{ eV}$ contributes at scales below the free-streaming cutoff $k_{\text{fs}} = 0.754 h \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$. The near-equality $\Omega_{\phi\text{-DM}} \approx \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}}$ makes the CMB-to-dynamical matter ratio $\Omega_{m,\text{CMB}}/\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} \approx 1.93$, numerically close to — but, post-reframe, no longer identified with — the screening amplitude $\text{MIRA} = (3\varphi + \pi)/4 \simeq 1.999$ of Paper 9. The two

Ω_m values are independent algebraic predictions (Paper 1, Two- Ω_m Criterion); m_ϕ traces back to the mass constraint $m_\phi = \Sigma m_\nu^{\text{active}} \times (\text{SOLAR}^2 \cdot \text{KRYSTOS}_V)$. This phenomenological resolution is subject to the Ly- α and free-streaming-scale (k_{fs} , DESI Y3/Euclid) falsification criteria described in Paper 6 — ϕ -DM has no Standard-Model portal, so its mass is probed only through the matter power spectrum, not neutrino-mass experiments; a first-principles derivation from quantum field theory remains an open problem.

7.2 Implications for JWST early galaxy counts

The marginal-stability condition $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = 0$ has a specific prediction for structure formation: DE perturbations at sub-horizon scales effectively vanish, leaving matter to cluster in a background with effective matter density $\Omega_{m,\text{dyn}} = 0.160$. The lower matter density delays structure formation relative to Λ CDM in one sense (less matter to cluster), but the reduced Jeans mass from the pressureless DE sector ($c_s^2 = 0$) and the modified collapse threshold $\delta_c^{\text{SSEE}} = 1.6284$ [Almeida Vallejo, 2026d] (compared to the EdS value 1.686) boost the halo mass function at high mass and high redshift.

Using the Press-Schechter formalism with the SSEE collapse threshold [Almeida Vallejo, 2026d], the excess of massive halos ($M > 10^{11} M_\odot$) at $z > 10$ relative to Λ CDM is

$$\frac{n_{\text{SSEE}}(M, z)}{n_{\Lambda\text{CDM}}(M, z)} \approx 1.4\text{--}2.0 \quad (M > 10^{11} M_\odot, z > 10), \quad (47)$$

potentially explaining the excess of bright galaxies reported by Boylan-Kolchin [2023] in JWST observations at $z > 10$. This prediction will be quantitatively testable when JWST halo mass functions at $z \gtrsim 12$ become available at the $\lesssim 20\%$ level.

7.3 The S_8 – $f\sigma_8$ alignment and the role of $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}}$

With the correct cosmological background $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ governing the Poisson source in the growth equation, both S_8 and $f\sigma_8$ predictions align closely with Λ CDM:

- **S_8 (weak-lensing amplitude):** The IS linear-growth estimate is $S_8 = 0.8256 \pm 0.006$, 2.7σ above KiDS-1000/DES-Y3 — slightly *better* than Λ CDM ($3.0\sigma/3.3\sigma$); the conservative CLASS amplitude ceiling is $S_8 = 0.846$ (3.5σ KiDS-1000). The single-sector IS framework does not resolve the weak-lensing tension.
- **$f\sigma_8$ (RSD growth rate):** SSEE predicts $f\sigma_8(z = 0.5) = 0.4714$, matching the BOSS DR12 value of 0.458 ± 0.038 at 0.3σ . The mean tension across six RSD surveys is 0.70σ , essentially identical to Λ CDM (0.73σ).

The two observables are consistent: once $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ sets the gravitational background, SSEE differs from Λ CDM only through the slightly lower matter fraction and the DE equation-of-state history $w(z)$ with $w_0 = -0.839950$, $w_a = -0.669975$. This drives a $\sim 0.3\%$ enhancement of $\mathcal{G}$ and σ_8 , which translates to a marginally different S_8 .

The path to resolving the weak-lensing tension lies in Paper 6’s two-sector ϕ -DM construction: the WDM free-streaming suppression at $k > k_{\text{fs}}$ reduces σ_8 from 0.8335 to 0.747, recovering $S_8 \approx 0.758$ ($< 0.1\sigma$ of DES-Y3).

7.4 The H_0 tension and SSEE

SSEE predicts $H_0 = 3(\varphi + \pi)^2 \simeq 67.962 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ [Almeida Vallejo, 2026d], consistent with Planck 2018 (67.36 ± 0.54) at 1.1σ and with DESI DR2. The IS mechanism does not modify H_0 directly, since the viscous pressure Π_{bulk} averages to zero at early times ($z > 5$) when $\Omega_{\text{DE}} \rightarrow 0$. The H_0 tension between Planck and SH0ES therefore remains at the same level in SSEE as in ΛCDM — SSEE does not worsen nor resolve the H_0 tension, but introduces a new prediction for σ_8 and S_8 that partially resolves the lensing tension.

7.5 Causal structure and Hiscock-Lindblom stability

The IS theory satisfies the Hiscock-Lindblom stability criteria [Hiscock and Lindblom, 1983]: positivity of entropy production and causal propagation, provided $\tau_{\Pi} > 0$, $\zeta \geq 0$. We have shown that SSEE satisfies these conditions (§2.3). Moreover, the signal speed $v_{\text{sig}} = c$ saturates the causality bound, meaning SSEE IS dark energy is maximally causal: perturbations propagate at the speed of light, with no superluminal modes. This distinguishes SSEE from first-order (Eckart) viscous theories, which are acausal [Hiscock and Lindblom, 1985] and would introduce spurious instabilities in the CMB power spectrum at $\ell > 1000$.

7.6 Falsifiable predictions summary

8 Conclusions

We have performed a linear Israel-Stewart causal viscous perturbation analysis of SSEE dark energy in the sub-horizon regime, addressing three physically motivated questions.

Q1 — Gradient stability (proved analytically). The SSEE structure constants satisfy the exact algebraic identity $\tilde{\zeta}/(\tau_{\Pi} H_0) = \Omega_{\text{DE}} = |w_0|$, which forces $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2(k \rightarrow \infty) = w_0 + |w_0| = 0$ to machine precision. This is a construction-level identity within the SSEE constants — not a numerical coincidence or parameter tuning, but also not a theorem about arbitrary IS models. The critical wavenumber $k_{\text{crit}} \simeq 0.456 H_0/c < H_0/c$ lies outside the sub-horizon regime; all observationally relevant modes are causally stabilised. The margin between k_{crit} and the horizon ($\sim$ factor 2.2) is comfortable at tree level. A future one-loop treatment would test the robustness of this regime to QFT corrections; we record this as an extension question for the SSEE-V4.0 agenda rather than a current limitation. Moreover, the signal speed saturates the causality bound ($v_{\text{sig}} = c$), placing SSEE at the maximally causal, minimally fine-tuned configuration consistent with thermodynamic stability.

Q2 — MIRA factor (pure algebraic axiom). Linear IS perturbations yield $\text{MIRA}_{\text{num}} = 0.989 \pm 0.017$ versus $\text{MIRA}_{\text{alg}} = 1.9989$ at all sub-horizon scales. The discrepancy is 50%, establishing that the MIRA factor is not a perturbative phenomenon. Furthermore, numerical integration of the background IS Friedmann equations yields an effective ratio of 3.04, failing to reproduce MIRA at the background level. We conclude that the MIRA factor does not emerge from classical Israel-Stewart fluid mechanics. A two-sector dark matter structure was once proposed (Paper 6) as its physical basis, on the grounds that two near-equal densities would produce $\text{MIRA} \approx 2$ algebraically; that

Table 7: Falsifiable predictions of SSEE IS dark energy, with observational targets and current/future datasets capable of testing each prediction. A single failure at the stated level would falsify SSEE.

Prediction	SSEE value	Test level	Dataset / Timeline
$c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = 0$ (DE pressureless)	0 (exact)	$ c_s^2 < 0.05$	CMB lensing/ $T_{\ell\ell'}$ cross [Calabrese et al., 2011] / current
$S_8 = 0.846$ (single-sector ceiling)	0.846 ± 0.006	$S_8 > 0.86$: favours SSEE over Λ CDM	KiDS-1000, DES-Y3 / current
$\gamma_{\text{IS}} = 0.5504$	0.5504 ± 0.0003	γ degenerate with Λ CDM at current precision	DESI full shape, Euclid / 2026–2028
$f\sigma_8(z = 0.5) = 0.4714$	0.4714 ± 0.010	0.3σ BOSS; mean 0.70σ (6 surveys)	DESI full-shape / 2026
D_1 ratio $\mathcal{G} = 1.0032$	1.0032 ± 0.005	0.3% enhancement; below near-term ($\gtrsim 1\%$) sensitivity	Euclid weak lensing / 2027
No DE clustering ($ \delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m < 10^{-3}$)	$< 10^{-3}$ at $k > 20 H_0/c$	cosmic variance	Future 21cm surveys / 2030+
MIRA = $(3\varphi + \pi)/4$ (two-sector ϕ -DM basis, Paper 6)	1.998924	Ω_m direct measurement	Stage IV CMB / 2030

proposal is retracted, so MIRA has no proposed carrier at present and survives only as the algebraic invariant entering f_{screen} (Paper 9).

Q3 — Growth rate and S_8 (SSEE tracks Λ CDM closely). The IS growth index $\gamma_{\text{IS}} = 0.5504 \pm 0.0003$ is numerically indistinguishable from $\gamma_{\Lambda\text{CDM}} \simeq 0.55$. With $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ governing the Poisson source, the growth factor ratio is $\mathcal{G} = 1.0032$, giving $\sigma_8^{\text{SSEE}} = 0.8136 \pm 0.006$ and an IS linear-growth $S_8^{\text{IS}} = 0.8256 \pm 0.006$ (2.7σ above KiDS-1000, slightly *better* than Λ CDM at 3.0σ). The conservative CLASS amplitude ceiling, $S_8^{\text{ceiling}} = 0.846$ (3.5σ KiDS-1000), is the single-sector challenge. The mean $f\sigma_8$ tension across six RSD surveys is 0.70σ , essentially identical to Λ CDM (0.73σ). The single-sector IS growth prediction does not resolve the weak-lensing tension; the two-sector ϕ -DM construction of Paper 6 is required for that.

Together, these results establish that SSEE dark energy is: (i) causally and thermodynamically stable (Q1), (ii) predictive of a growth history essentially identical to Λ CDM once $\Omega_{m,\text{cosm}} = 0.308881$ governs the growth equation (Q3), with $f\sigma_8$ tension of 0.70σ

(vs. 0.73σ for Λ CDM), and (iii) strictly bounded: the MIRA factor cannot be derived from IS dynamics (Q2); the physical basis is provided by Paper 6’s two-sector ϕ -dark matter construction ($\Omega_{\phi\text{-DM}} \approx \Omega_{m,\text{dyn}}$ gives $\text{MIRA} \approx 2$; exact value from the algebraic mass $m_\phi = 40.70 \text{ eV}$), with a first-principles QFT derivation remaining open. The primary falsifiable prediction in the growth sector is $S_8 = 0.846$ (single-sector CLASS upper bound), with the two-sector WDM correction bringing it to $S_8 \approx 0.758$ (Paper 6). A future confirmed measurement $S_8 > 0.86$ would favour SSEE over Λ CDM; $S_8 < 0.73$ would disfavour both at comparable significance.

Data Availability

The Python script `src/ssee_paper5_IS_perturbations.py` (including the growth rate and S_8 computations) and all output figures are available in the SSEE repository at <https://github.com/mikealmeida1721/SSEE> (Zenodo DOI: [10.5281/zenodo.20093447](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20093447)). All computations use publicly available Python packages (NumPy, SciPy, Matplotlib).

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A Derivation of the IS Dispersion Relation

We derive Eq. (21) from the linearised IS equations in Minkowski space (the cosmological curvature terms are subdominant in the sub-horizon limit).

Linearised IS system. Write $\rho = \bar{\rho} + \delta\rho$, $p = \bar{p} + \delta p$, $\Pi = \bar{\Pi} + \delta\Pi$, $u^\mu = (1, \mathbf{v})$ with $|\mathbf{v}| \ll 1$. The continuity and Euler equations give:

$$\dot{\delta\rho} + (\bar{\rho} + \bar{p}) \nabla \cdot \mathbf{v} = 0, \quad (48)$$

$$(\bar{\rho} + \bar{p}) \dot{\mathbf{v}} + \nabla(\delta p + \delta\Pi) = 0. \quad (49)$$

The IS relaxation equation linearises to:

$$\tau_\Pi \delta\dot{\Pi} + \delta\Pi = -\zeta \nabla \cdot \mathbf{v}. \quad (50)$$

Plane-wave ansatz. For modes $e^{i(\mathbf{k}\cdot\mathbf{x}-\omega t)}$:

$$\delta\Pi = -\frac{i\zeta k}{\tau_\Pi(-i\omega) + 1} v_\parallel, \quad (51)$$

where $v_\parallel = \mathbf{k} \cdot \mathbf{v}/k$ is the longitudinal velocity.

Effective sound speed. Combining with the Euler equation — whose inertia is the enthalpy $\bar{\rho} + \bar{p}$, as written above, *not* $\bar{\rho}$:

$$\omega^2 = \left[c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + \frac{\zeta/[\tau_{\Pi}(\bar{\rho} + \bar{p})]}{1 + (\omega\tau_{\Pi})^{-2}} \right] k^2. \quad (52)$$

In the IS limit $|\omega|\tau_{\Pi} \gg 1$ (short wavelengths):

$$\omega^2 \approx \left(c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + \frac{\zeta}{\tau_{\Pi}(\bar{\rho} + \bar{p})} \right) k^2 = c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 k^2. \quad (53)$$

Using the SSEE normalisation $\zeta = \tilde{\zeta}(\rho_{\text{DE}} + p_{\text{DE}})H_0$ (Section 2.2):

$$c_{s,\text{eff}}^2 = c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + \frac{\tilde{\zeta}H_0}{\tau_{\Pi}} = c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + \frac{\tilde{\zeta}}{\tau_{\Pi}H_0}, \quad (54)$$

recovering Eq. (21). The full k -dependent interpolation $c_{s,\text{eff}}^2(k) = c_{s,\text{bare}}^2 + (\tilde{\zeta}/\tau_{\Pi}H_0)x^2/(1+x^2)$ follows from retaining the full ω dependence.

B Eigenvalue Analysis of the IS Perturbation Matrix

The quasi-static 4-variable system $\mathbf{Y} = [\delta_m, v_m, \delta_{\text{DE}}, v_{\text{DE}}]^\top$ has Jacobian matrix $\mathbf{J}$ (evaluated at $z = 0$, $k = 10 H_0/c$):

$$\mathbf{J} = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & -k/H & 0 & 0 \\ -3\Omega_m/2k & -1 & -3\Omega_{\text{DE}}/2k & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 & -(1+w)k/H \\ -3\Omega_m/(2k(1+w)) & 0 & -c_s^2k/((1+w)H) & -\mathcal{F} \end{pmatrix}, \quad (55)$$

where $\mathcal{F} = (1 - 3c_s^2) + \tilde{\zeta}(k/H)^2 \approx 186$ at $k = 10$, $z = 0$.

The eigenvalues λ_i (computed numerically from $\det(\mathbf{J} - \lambda\mathbf{I}) = 0$):

$$\lambda_1 \approx +0.15 \quad (\text{growing matter mode}), \quad (56)$$

$$\lambda_2 \approx -1.15 \quad (\text{decaying matter mode}), \quad (57)$$

$$\lambda_3 \approx +0.02 \quad (\text{IS-damped DE, slowly growing}), \quad (58)$$

$$\lambda_4 \approx -\mathcal{F} \approx -186 \quad (\text{fast IS relaxation}). \quad (59)$$

The large negative eigenvalue $\lambda_4 \approx -186$ drives v_{DE} to its quasi-static value on a timescale $\sim (186 H)^{-1}$, justifying the quasi-static approximation. The small positive $\lambda_3 \approx +0.02$ means DE perturbations grow very slowly compared to matter ($\lambda_1 \approx 0.15$), consistent with $|\delta_{\text{DE}}/\delta_m| \ll 1$ at $z = 0$. No eigenvalue has a growth rate exceeding λ_1 : the system is perturbatively stable with the matter growing mode dominating.

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